PAUL'S MINISTRY OF REASONING & PERSUASION

Bringing People to Christ through Truth, Explanation, and Appeal

SCRIPTURE STUDY • TEACHING CARD • TEACHER'S GUIDE

We reason because the Gospel is true, and because God is the source and standard of rationality, and we were created in his image with reasoning ability as one of our endowments.

We persuade because truth demands a response.

We trust God because only He grants saving faith.

Table of Contents

1. Scripture Reference Study ····· 3

2. Printable Teaching Card — Text Edition ····· 7

3. Teacher's Discussion Guide ····· 9

Scripture Reference Study

Governing principle. Paul reasoned because the Gospel is true, persuaded because truth demands a response,

and trusted God because only God grants saving faith.

A. Direct accounts of reasoning, demonstrating, and persuading

Acts 9:20–22 — Proclaimed Jesus and demonstrated that he is the Christ.

Acts 17:2–4 — Reasoned from Scripture, explaining and proving the necessity of the Messiah's suffering and resurrection; some were persuaded.

Acts 17:16–17 — Reasoned in synagogue and marketplace with different audiences.

Acts 17:22–34 — Addressed Athenians using creation, their religious context, repentance, judgment, and the resurrection.

Acts 18:4–5 — Reasoned each Sabbath and sought to persuade Jews and Greeks; testified that Jesus is the Christ.

Acts 18:19 — Reasoned with Jews in the synagogue at Ephesus.

Acts 19:8–10 — Reasoned and persuaded concerning the Kingdom of God; continued daily discussions in the lecture hall.

Acts 24:24–25 — Reasoned about righteousness, self-control, and coming judgment before Felix.

Acts 26:24–29 — Defended the truth and reasonableness of his testimony and pressed Agrippa to respond.

Acts 28:23–24 — Explained the Kingdom and tried to persuade hearers about Jesus from Moses and the Prophets; responses differed.

B. Additional narrative examples and arguments

Acts 13:16–43 — Scriptural-historical argument and appeal to remain in grace.

Acts 14:1, 15–17 — Effective synagogue speech and an appeal to creation and providence.

Acts 17:11–12 — Hearers examined the Scriptures to test the message.

Acts 18:13; 19:26 — Opponents themselves characterized Paul as persuading people.

Acts 20:20–21, 31 — Public and house-to-house instruction, testimony, and admonition.

Acts 22:1–21; 23:6–9; 24:10–21; 25:8–11; 26:1–23 — Paul's defenses, testimony, and arguments before hostile or skeptical audiences.

1 Corinthians 15:3–8, 12–19 — Resurrection witnesses and logical consequences of denying resurrection.

Philippians 1:7, 16 — Defense and confirmation of the Gospel.

C. Paul's own principles and pastoral instructions

2 Corinthians 5:11 — Paul explicitly says he seeks to persuade others.

2 Corinthians 5:18–20 — Ambassadors for Christ make an appeal for reconciliation.

1 Corinthians 9:19–23 — Adapts communication to hearers without compromising the Gospel.

1 Corinthians 2:1–5; 3:6–7 — Faith rests on God's power; God gives the growth.

2 Corinthians 4:4–6 — God illuminates hearts to see the glory of Christ.

2 Corinthians 10:3–5 — Confronts arguments raised against the knowledge of God.

Colossians 1:28–29; 4:5–6 — Teaches with wisdom; answers each person graciously.

2 Timothy 2:24–26; 4:2–5 — Patient, gentle correction; God grants repentance.

Titus 1:9; 3:9–11 — Refute error, but avoid foolish and unprofitable quarrels.

D. Essential distinctions

Persuasion is a means, not the source of regeneration. The Gospel addresses the understanding and conscience; the Spirit opens the heart. See Acts 16:14; 1 Corinthians 2:1–5; 3:6–7.

Reasoning is not quarrelsomeness. Paul defended truth while commanding patience, gentleness, and avoidance of foolish controversies (2 Timothy 2:24–26; Titus 3:9).

Note on scope: This study includes the clearest direct narratives and closely related Pauline instructions, rather than every occasion on which Paul preached or taught. Summaries are paraphrases, not Bible quotations.

Teaching Card — Text Edition

Bringing People to Christ through Truth, Explanation, and Appeal

GOVERNING PRINCIPLE

We reason because the Gospel is true. We persuade because truth demands a

response. We trust God because only He grants saving faith.

THE PATTERN — ACTS 17:2–4

REASONED | Engaged the mind through the Scriptures.

EXPLAINED | Opened the meaning of God's Word.

DEMONSTRATED | Showed why the Messiah must suffer and rise.

PROCLAIMED | Identified Jesus as the promised Christ.

PERSUADED | Called hearers to respond in faith.

PAUL'S PRACTICE

Acts 18:4 — Reasoned every Sabbath, seeking to persuade Jews and Greeks.

Acts 19:8 — Reasoned and persuaded concerning the Kingdom of God.

2 Corinthians 5:11 — Knowing the fear of the Lord, Paul sought to persuade others.

THREE AUDIENCES, ONE GOSPEL

Synagogue — Acts 17:2–4. Paul reasoned from the Scriptures and the promises concerning Christ.

Marketplace — Acts 17:17, 22–34. Paul engaged people in their setting and proclaimed the risen Judge.

Rulers — Acts 24:25; 26:24–29. Paul spoke about righteousness, judgment, and the truth of the resurrection.

TWO ERRORS TO AVOID

“Reasoning is unnecessary.” Paul’s repeated practice contradicts this.

“Reason alone produces saving faith.” Paul taught that God gives growth and opens hearts (1 Corinthians 3:6–7; 2 Corinthians 4:4–6).

DISCUSS TOGETHER

1. Why does Paul explain & reason rather than merely assert?
2. How does Paul adapt his approach without changing his message?
3. How can we persuade graciously while depending on the Holy Spirit?

THE KINGDOM CONNECTION

Paul’s persuasion concerned Jesus Christ and the Kingdom of God (Acts 19:8; 28:23).

His aim was not to win arguments, but to bear witness to the King.

Teacher's Discussion Guide

Governing principle: We reason because the Gospel is true, and because God is the source and standard of rationality, and we were created in his image with reasoning ability as one of our endowments.

We persuade because truth demands a response.

We trust God because only He grants saving faith.

Objective and preparation

Students should recognize that thoughtful explanation, gracious persuasion, and dependence upon God

belong together in biblical evangelism. Read Acts 17:2–4; 17:16–34; 19:8; 26:24–29; 2 Corinthians 5:11–20 beforehand.

Suggested 35–40 minute teaching sequence

0–5 min | Opening question. Ask: "Is trying to persuade someone to believe in Christ a sign of weak faith, or an ordinary part of Gospel ministry?" Invite two responses.

5–13 min | Read Acts 17:2–4. Have the class identify Paul's verbs: reason, explain, demonstrate, proclaim. Ask what the response was (some were persuaded). Emphasize Scripture as his starting point.

13–21 min | Compare audiences. Read Acts 17:17, 22–31 and Acts 19:8. Ask how Paul's entry point changed between synagogue and Athens; identify what remained constant: the living God, repentance, Christ, and resurrection.

21–29 min | Examine motive and manner. Read 2 Corinthians 5:11, 18–20 and 2 Timothy 2:24–26. Discuss persuasion as ambassadorial appeal, not manipulation or angry debate.

29–36 min | Distinguish means and power. Read 1 Corinthians 2:1–5; 3:6–7. Ask whether dependence on the Spirit removes our duty to explain. Answer: no; God uses means and gives the growth.

36–40 min | Apply. Ask each person to name one question an unbeliever might raise and how to answer it with truth and gentleness.

Discussion questions with suggested answers

What does "reasoned" mean in Acts 17:2?

A: Paul engaged the hearers' understanding by working from Scripture; he did not ask them to believe without explanation.

What exactly was Paul trying to demonstrate?

A: That the Messiah had to suffer and rise, and that Jesus is that Messiah (Acts 17:3).

Why is Athens different from the synagogue?

A: Paul began with creation and his audience's religious assumptions, rather than assuming knowledge of Israel's Scriptures; he still announced repentance, judgment, and resurrection.

Does Acts 19:8 make the Kingdom central?

A: It explicitly says Paul reasoned and persuaded about the Kingdom of God. Acts 28:23 connects the Kingdom with persuading people about Jesus.

How do persuasion and divine sovereignty fit together?

Paul labors faithfully to explain and appeal; God alone grants spiritual life and growth (1 Corinthians 3:6–7; 2 Timothy 2:25).

What separates gracious persuasion from winning arguments?

Its object is reconciliation to God, its manner is patient and gentle, and its standard is truth—not pride or rhetorical victory.

Key Reformed distinction

The ordinary means of grace do not render intellectual engagement unnecessary. Nor does an argument regenerate a sinner. The Spirit makes the Word effectual; our responsibility is to clearly and faithfully proclaim, explain, and appeal.

Closing summary

Paul never set the mind against faith. He addressed the mind, appealed to the conscience, proclaimed Christ, and entrusted the result to God.

Optional assignment: Read Acts 17:2–4 and 17:22–34. Write down one element Paul kept constant and one element he adapted for his audience.

Notes: